



Defending the crown: The young Uzbekistan men's team stunned the favourites — the USA, China, and India — to claim the title at the last Chess Olympiad in Mahabalipuram. STEV BONHAGE

management skills. Srinath, who was the non-playing captain in the last Olympiad and the Asian Games in Hangzhou, will continue in the same role for the men's team.

Gukesh, Erigaisi, and Praggnanandhaa — three of India's top chess talents — have previously teamed up in various events and are expected to replicate their individual brilliance as they come together once more.

On the other hand, the aura of invincibility surrounding the heavyweight USA team has faded

somewhat in the absence of world No. 2 Hikaru Nakamura, who has opted to skip the multi-nation tournament for the second consecutive time. However, the USA still boasts two of the world's strongest chess players — Fabiano Caruana and Wesley So. Alongside experienced Levon Aronian and Leinier Dominguez Perez, the top-seeded USA remains a title favourite.

India should also keep a close eye on the Chinese team, led by Wei Yi. The defending world champion,

Ding, and Yu Yangyi form a powerful trio, making China a strong contender for a podium finish and possibly even a top-two spot, with an average rating of 2726.

While the board order has yet to be finalised, a potential Ding vs. Gukesh clash is likely to be a thrilling preview of their upcoming world championship match in November and December.

However, the true challenge may come from the defending champion, Uzbekistan. This young and extraordinarily talented team stunned the favourites — the USA, China, and India — to claim the title in Mahabalipuram. Despite being one of the youngest squads, with four players born after 2002, the Uzbeks are fully capable of defending their crown. With rising stars like Nodirbek Abdusattorov, Javokhir Sindarov, and Nodirbek Yakubboev, their team is reminiscent of the Indian setup.

In a bid to defend its crown, Uzbekistan roped in former world champion, Russia's master tactician Vladimir Kramnik as the coach. Kramnik will also be the non-participating captain.

While the wait for an Olympiad medal from Magnus Carlsen (Norway) and Anish Giri (Netherlands) might persist given their teams' past performances, host Hungary and Iran could emerge as dark horses this time around.

Hungary, with Richard Rapport



Top five seeds in the Open section

1. United States (2758) Captain: John Donaldson
Fabiano Caruana (2796); Wesley So (2757); Leinier Dominguez Perez (2748); Levon Aronian (2729); Ray Robson (2700)

2. India (2755) Captain: Srinath Narayanan
Arjun Erigaisi (2778); D. Gukesh (2763); R. Praggnanandhaa (2757); Vidit Santosh Gujrathi (2720); Pentala Harikrishna (2695)

3. China (2729) Captain: Yang Wen
Wei Yi (2755); Ding Liren (2745); Yu Yangyi (2720); Bu Xiangzhi (2697); Wang Yue (2652)

4. Uzbekistan (2684) Captain: Vladimir Kramnik
Nodirbek Abdusattorov (2769); Javokhir Sindarov (2674); Nodirbek Yakubboev (2648); Shamsiddin Vokhidov (2643); Jakhongir Vakhidov (2571)

5. Netherlands (2679) Captain: Jan Smeets
Anish Giri (2745); Jorden Van Foreest (2671); Max Warmerdam (2663); Erwin L'ami (2635); Benjamin Bok (2587)